THE NITISH YEARS

From socialist beginnings to decades at the centre of Bihar's political power



SAXENA SHARAD

1985: After losing in 1977 & 1980, wins his first assembly seat from Harnaut on a Janata ticket

1989: Elected to the Lok Sabha from Barh

1994: Co-founds the Samata Party with George Fernandes, emerging as a key anti-RJD leader in Bihar

1998-2001: Serves as Union minister in the Vajpayee government, prominently as rail minister

2000: Becomes Bihar CM for the first time, but has to quit within a week as a majority eludes him



2001-04: Union rail minister again

2003: The JD(U) is formed as the Samata Party (Nitish faction), Janata Dal (Sharad Yadav faction) and Lok Shakti Party merge

2015: CM again after removing Manjhi in Feb. Wins polls in Nov. with RJD alliance

2017: Flip-flop again, returns to NDA

2020: Wins assembly poll, but JD(U) poorer in tally of seats

2022: Leaves NDA to form govt with RJD alliance again

2024: Rejoins NDA in another dramatic realignment

2025: Takes oath for a 10th term as CM after NDA wins assembly poll

2026: Files RS nomination while serving as CM



ANI

the CM's post going to the BJP, and the deputy CM positions to the allies.

WHY NITISH QUIT

In the November 2025 Bihar election, the BJP won 89 out of the 100 seats it contested, while the JD(U) got 85 of the 100 it fought . With senior BJP leaders like Amit Shah and Dharmendra Pradhan steering the alliance and shaping the narrative, political observers believe Nitish's transition was inevitable; only its timing was uncertain. The earliest signal came when Nitish was not allowed to retain the crucial home department.

Even so, why did he quit so soon into his new term? Political observers are looking at three factors. The first: age. Nitish turned 75 at the beginning of March, and discussions about his erratic health had circulated for months within political circles. Second: coalition arithmetic. With the BJP holding more seats in the assembly, its claim to the leadership within the National Democratic Alliance has grown stronger. Third: strategic calculation. Moving to the Rajya Sabha affords Nitish a dignified exit that avoids open conflict within the alliance while also retaining national stature.

THE JD(U) DILEMMA

For nearly two decades, the party's image has been inseparable from Nitish's personal credibility and *sushasan babu* (good governance) persona. With Nitish moving on, anxious party workers began gathering outside his residence in Patna within hours of his announcement. Sources say senior leaders and family members—including son Nishant—tried their best to persuade him to reconsider. But the very fact that such a transition was being openly discussed revealed how rapidly Bihar's political centre of gravity had shifted.

Nitish's senior lieutenants—Sanjay Jha, Vijay Choudhary, Ashok Choudhary and Lalan Singh—are veteran organisational figures. But none of them can command the roughly 16 per cent vote base of Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs) and part of the Kurmis that has remained loyal to Nitish across shifting alliances. Without his personal connect, the JD(U) risks rapid disintegration, especially with the BJP, now the senior ally, breathing down its neck. Perhaps why some in the party want Nishant to take on his mantle, believing the support base would gravitate towards him. But Nishant, whose quiet